

Making judgments

The Internet is full of content—ads, news, opinions, photos, and stories—produced by and shared on many different sources. It can be hard to know what and who to trust, so approaching information with a critical eye is the best way to separate fact from fiction.

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False information

False information can be shared in articles by journalists who haven't properly checked the facts, or spread by people or organizations who want others to believe inaccurate information to suit their own agenda. It's a big problem because people can start to believe things that aren't true or can claim that something is fake just because they disagree with it.



△ Checking multiple sources

Teens can watch out for fake news by seeing if the story is being reported on the radio, on TV, or in newspapers.

Questions to ask

- Are other sites reporting this story? What is their response to it?
- Who put this information there and why?
- Is there any evidence to support what's being said here?
- Does the site have an editorial bias? Some sites have a particular political or cultural outlook that affects what news they report and how.

What to look out for

All sorts of content appears on the Internet, so it's always essential to be on guard for false and inaccurate information, or for sites that contain malware that can cause harm to electronic devices.

Clickbait

These links play on people's curiosity to get them to click. They usually have outrageous headlines and promise to shock the reader, but typically lead to inaccurate and false content. They may also direct users to sites with viruses—malicious software that can damage computers.

Sponsored posts

Blogs and social media sites often feature "sponsored posts," where a company pays to promote a product. The site or blogger is supposed to announce that the post is an advertisement. The reviews of the product are typically favorable and encourage people to buy the product.

Pop-up ads

These ads appear on certain websites. They normally open in a new window. It's possible to download software to block pop-up ads. It's best not to click on them, as more might appear, or they might start to download unwanted files onto the computer.